SWIM SAFETY POSTER PACK

Victorian Secondary HPE · Year 7 & 8 · Print at A3 for best results

Victorian Curriculum 2.0 · HPE · Safety Focus Area

🩺 POSTER 1 OF 4

EMERGENCY ACTION PLAN

DRS ABCD

WHAT TO DO WHEN SOMEONE IS IN DANGER NEAR WATER

D — DANGER
Check for danger to yourself, bystanders, and the casualty. Never enter dangerous water to rescue someone — throw, don't go.

R — RESPONSE
Check if the person responds. Tap their shoulder firmly. Call out loudly. If no response, they need urgent help.

S — SEND FOR HELP

A — AIRWAY

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Call **000** (Australia) immediately. Tell them your location, what happened, and how many are injured.

Open the airway by tilting the head back and lifting the chin. Look in the mouth for any obstructions and clear if visible.

B

BREATHING

Look, listen and feel for breathing for up to 10 seconds. If not breathing normally, begin CPR immediately.

C

CPR

30 chest compressions (hard and fast) followed by 2 rescue breaths. Continue until help arrives or the person recovers.

D

DEFIBRILLATION (AED)

Use an AED (defibrillator) as soon as one is available. Turn it on and follow the voice prompts. AEDs are designed to be used by anyone. For aquatic environments, ensure the casualty is out of the water before using.

⚠️ **CRITICAL RULE — THROW, DON'T GO: Most drowning bystanders who enter the water to help also drown. Always attempt a reach or throw rescue first. Call 000 before anything else.**

Sources: St John Ambulance Victoria – https://www.stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-resources/ | Life Saving Victoria – https://lsv.com.au | Royal Life Saving Society Australia – https://www.royallifesaving.com.au | AUSTSWIM – https://austswim.com.au | Curriculum: Victorian Curriculum 2.0 HPE VC2HP8P10 – https://f10.vcaa.vic.edu.au | DE Swimming Policy – https://www2.education.vic.gov.au/pal/swimming-instruction-and-water-safety-education/policy

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KNOW THE SIGNALS

BEACH FLAGS & WATER SAFETY

READ THE FLAGS — THEY CAN SAVE YOUR LIFE



🔴🟡 Red & Yellow Flags

ALWAYS swim here. This is the patrolled area, supervised by lifeguards. The safest zone on any beach.



🔴 Single Red Flag

Dangerous conditions. Strong surf, large waves or powerful rip currents. Do not swim unless you are an experienced swimmer.



⬛⬜ Black & White Quartered

Surfers and watercraft zone. Surfboards, bodyboards, kayaks. Swimmers must stay out of this area.



🟡⚫ Yellow + Black Ball

No surfboards or non-powered watercraft. Swimming only in this zone — boards and bodyboards prohibited.

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🟠 Orange Windsock

Offshore winds. Inflatables (lilos, rings) must not be used — they will be carried out to sea.



🟣 Purple Flag

Dangerous marine life. Jellyfish, stingrays or similar have been spotted. Swim with caution.

🌊 CAUGHT IN A RIP? HERE'S WHAT TO DO:

Stay calm — don't panic or fight the current. **Float** and conserve energy. Swim **parallel to the shore** (not directly in) to escape the current's narrow channel, then angle back to the beach at an angle. If unable to swim, **raise one arm** and signal for help from lifeguards.

SWIM BETWEEN THE FLAGS · CHECK CONDITIONS · NEVER SWIM ALONE

Sources: Life Saving Victoria – https://lsv.com.au | LSV Toolkit – https://lsv.com.au/toolkit | Surf Life Saving Australia – https://sls.com.au | BeachSafe App – https://beachsafe.org.au | Victoria Police Water Safety – https://www.police.vic.gov.au/beach-and-waterways-safety | Paddle Australia (inland waterways) – https://paddle.org.au | Parks Victoria – https://www.parks.vic.gov.au | Curriculum: VC2HP8P10 – https://f10.vcaa.vic.edu.au

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VICTORIA'S DROWNING CRISIS

WHY WATER SAFETY MATTERS

REAL VICTORIAN DATA — THIS AFFECTS PEOPLE YOUR AGE

54
Fatal drownings in Victoria in 2024–25 — the most in decades

1 in 5
Drowning victims were aged 15–24 years old

4×
Males are four times more likely to drown than females

132
Non-fatal drownings in 2024–25 — 60% above the 10-year average

50%
Of deaths happened over the summer months (Dec–Feb)

0
Deaths in 2024–25 occurred at patrolled beach locations

⚠️ Highest Risk Settings

💡 Why Young People Are at Risk

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Rivers, lakes, dams and unpatrolled beaches account for the majority of Victorian drowning deaths. Inland waterways have hidden currents, cold water, and submerged hazards.

Risk-taking behaviour, overestimating swimming ability, peer pressure, and swimming at unpatrolled locations are key factors in teen drowning incidents.

🌡️ Cold Water Shock

Victoria's waterways can be cold year-round. Sudden cold water causes an involuntary gasp reflex and rapid breathing — even strong swimmers can drown within minutes.

🍺 Alcohol & Water

Alcohol is a factor in a significant proportion of adult drownings. It impairs judgment, reduces coordination, slows reaction times, and causes overconfidence around water.

🛡️ KEY PREVENTION ACTIONS:

- Swim between the flags
- Never swim alone
- Learn CPR & rescue skills
- Know the BeachSafe app
- Avoid alcohol near water
- Check conditions first
- Wear a lifejacket on boats

Sources: Life Saving Victoria Drowning Report 2023–24 – https://lsv.com.au/what-we-do/research-advocacy | Victorian Government Water Safety – https://www.vic.gov.au/water-safety | Royal Life Saving Society Australia – https://www.royallifesaving.com.au | CDC Drowning Prevention – https://www.cdc.gov/drowning/prevention | Curriculum: VC2HP8P09 · VC2HP8P10 – https://f10.vcaa.vic.edu.au

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LSV SWIMSAFE RULES

SWIMSAFE

LIFE SAVING VICTORIA'S 5 RULES — KNOW THEM BEFORE YOU GO NEAR WATER

READ SIGNS

Always read warning signs, beach flags, and safety notices before entering any water. Signs communicate real hazards — rip currents, dangerous depths, no-swimming zones. If there are no flags, that means no lifeguard supervision — reconsider swimming.

ENTER FEET FIRST

Never dive or jump into unknown water. Hidden rocks, submerged logs, sand banks, and shallow edges cause serious spinal injuries every year. Always test the depth before you commit. At rivers and dams, the edge can drop away suddenly.

STAY IN DEPTH

Only swim in water where you can comfortably stand up, unless you are a confident swimmer. Water conditions can change quickly — waves, currents, and cold water shock can all overwhelm you even in familiar settings.

SWIM WITH A FRIEND

Never swim alone. A companion can call 000, throw you a rescue aid, or raise the alarm. Drowning is silent — if no one is watching, no one will know you are in trouble. The buddy system saves lives every summer.

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SIGNAL FOR HELP

If you get into trouble in water — raise ONE arm above your head and call out loudly. This is the universal signal for a swimmer in distress. Stay as calm as possible, float on your back to conserve energy, and keep signalling until help arrives. If you see someone else signalling, tell a lifeguard immediately or call **000**.

> 🌊 **BONUS RULE — THROW, DON'T GO: If someone is in trouble in the water, do NOT jump in to save them — most untrained bystanders who enter the water to help also drown. Throw a rope, towel, pool noodle, esky lid, or any floating object from the bank. Stay safe so you can keep helping.**

Source: Life Saving Victoria (LSV) SwimSafe Program – https://lsv.com.au | LSV Classroom Resources – https://lsv.com.au/toolkit | Victorian Government Water Safety – https://www.vic.gov.au/water-safety-programs | Curriculum: VC2HP8P10 – https://f10.vcaa.vic.edu.au

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